



cameras. Let's start with the primary 1-inch Sony IMX989 camera. Shots taken from this lens have fantastic detail and sharpness with good colour, in most instances. You can see in this photo of the red metal door, the colours look true to life with no unnecessary boost in contrast. The lens also captures fantastic shallow depth of field when it is on f/1.9 aperture allowing you to click some truly gorgeous shots like this one of the bell.

However, we did notice some instances where the pictures taken from the primary camera with f/1.9 aperture overexposed the highlights. You can see an example below – take a look at the melons at the bottom of the picture. To be fair, this can be combated by changing the aperture to f/4.0 since there was plenty of daylight around, but not all of us will have the time to make minor adjustments like this for every shot. Nevertheless, the primary camera is solid in daylight. Due to our limited time with the device, we didn't get to test low-light photography, but the large sensor gives us confidence that you should get some crisp shots in low light as well. We also tested out the ultrawide camera and were pleased with the colour consistency between this lens and the primary lens. Pictures taken from this camera have pleasing

colours and good dynamic range but there's slight barrelling in the corners.

Moving on to my absolute favourite part of the Xiaomi 13 Ultra's camera – portrait photos. I can say, without dispute, this is the best portrait smartphone camera I've ever tested and I've used devices such as the Vivo X80 Pro, Samsung Galaxy S23 Ultra, Pixel 7 Pro, and even used the Vivo X90 Pro for a short period. All focal lengths cough up amazing portrait photos but my favourite would be 75 mm for sure. The portrait shots exude a subtle confidence with natural-looking bokeh, good edge detection, and great exposure – making them seem closer than ever to DSLR quality. Black and white portrait shots look out of this world with extremely crisp detail when it comes to skin textures while looking aesthetically pleasing.

My only critique would be that Xiaomi allows for a 90 mm portrait mode with a Soft Focus on and off toggle. Soft Focus looks good only for specific shots, so it ends up being unused for most of the time. Now, since I had the device for about 5-6 hours, I couldn't click too many low-light shots or selfie shots, so I won't be able to comment on those aspects. Overall though, after taking about 50-60 portrait images from this device, I can say that the Xiaomi 13 Ultra is

the absolute best portrait smartphone camera I've tested. And the overall camera system is also mighty impressive – sans the occasional overblown highlights and the barrelling in ultrawide shots.

Price and availability

The Xiaomi 13 Ultra is available in Mainland China and is coming to various international markets very soon. Unfortunately, India is not one of them at the moment. It is available in three main colours – Black, White, and Olive Green. However, at Coonoor, we also saw a few limited edition colour variants.

The phone is priced at RMB 5,999 (approximately ₹69,549) for the 12 GB + 256 GB model, RMB 6,499 (approximately ₹75,346) for the 16 GB + 512 GB model, and RMB 7,299 (approximately ₹84,620) for the 16 GB + 1 TB model.

The final word

As someone who daily drives the Samsung Galaxy S23 Ultra, the Xiaomi 13 Ultra altered what I considered to be the pinnacle of smartphone portrait photography. The Xiaomi 13 Ultra is now a new benchmark for portrait photography – one that comes as close as a smartphone can get to DSLR or mirrorless camera quality. Crisp portrait shots with excellent edge detection, solid colour, and aesthetically-pleasing filters are what you can expect from this phone without going through the effort of turning on Pro Mode. The primary camera is also extremely capable in most scenarios but there are some instances of overblown highlights. But these are few and far between. The Xiaomi 13 Ultra is the lovechild of Xiaomi and Leica – a majorly successful collaboration that has produced some of the best smartphone cameras to date, and we're hopeful they will continue to do so. We're also hoping the next Ultra model reaches Indian shores so that users here can experience some of the Xiaomi x Leica magic as well! 